

The *Narrow Agent Fit* Checklist

Run this against any repeated business process before you build, buy, or hire for it. Six checks, in order, built on the shape that actually works: read the input, check it against one reference, decide match or mismatch, escalate only what doesn't match. Failing a check tells you exactly what to fix first, not that the whole idea is wrong.

RUN THESE SIX, IN ORDER

Rust means it's a call you can make alone today. Gold means check with whoever already does this work by hand. Sage on the last check means you have a green light.

- ☐ **1 Can you name the input and the output in one sentence each?** YOURS
"An invoice becomes a ledger entry" is narrow enough. "Invoices get handled" is not. Split the process before you build anything against it.
- ☐ **2 Is there one reference record to check the input against?** YOURS
A purchase order, a contract, a price list, last month's number. No reference means there's nothing to decide against, only something to read.
- ☐ **3 Does that check resolve to a clean match or mismatch?** YOURS
If a person answering honestly says "it depends" more than once in five tries, the decision needs judgment an agent doesn't have yet.
- ☐ **4 Can a human review only what didn't match?** NEEDS A TEAMMATE
Ask whoever runs this today how many cases actually need a second look in a normal week. Most of them means you've relocated the work, not reduced it.
- ☐ **5 Does this happen often enough to be worth building?** YOURS
Count occurrences over the last month, not how tedious it feels. A few a week justifies it. A few a quarter doesn't. Keep doing it by hand.
- ☐ **6 Is a wrong decision recoverable, or catastrophic?** YOU'RE DONE
Correctable next cycle: build the narrow agent. Can't be undone: keep a person fully in the loop and automate only the reading for now, not the deciding.

What a good fit looks like

Invoice matching. Read the line items off the invoice, check them against the purchase order, decide match or mismatch, escalate only the mismatches. Narrow input, one reference, a clean decision, exceptions only reaching a person.

What isn't ready yet

"Handle customer complaints." No single reference to check against, no clean match or mismatch, a judgment call on nearly every case. Fix the process into something narrower first, or keep a person on it for now.

NEXT STEP

If check six came back "recoverable," you likely have a process that fits this shape today. I build exactly this for finance and ops teams: read, check, decide, escalate. **Book a free 20-minute brief** and we'll work out whether it's a narrow agent, a workflow tool, or a person, before you spend anything on any of them.

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